

MUAY THAI

4-WEEK CARDIO TRAINING PLAN

Build fight-ready conditioning from scratch.
Go from gassing out in round 1 to lasting 5 full rounds.

Most Muay Thai beginners train techniques but neglect cardio — then wonder why they can't make it through a full class. This 4-week plan is built specifically around Muay Thai energy demands: short explosive bursts, active recovery, and the kind of full-body conditioning you need for real training. No gym required for most sessions.

HOW TO USE THIS PLAN

Round timing: 3 minutes on, 1 minute rest — always. This mirrors real Muay Thai round structure.

Intensity scale: RPE (Rate of Perceived Exertion) out of 10. RPE 6 = can talk but breathing hard. RPE 8 = can't hold a conversation. RPE 10 = max effort.

Rest days are mandatory. Your cardio improves during recovery, not during training.

Equipment needed: jump rope, heavy bag (optional), timer app on phone.

WEEK 1 — BUILD THE BASE

Goal: Establish your aerobic base. Everything at moderate intensity. Don't push to failure.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	Roadwork (steady run)	30 min	RPE 6 — conversational pace
Tue	Jump rope + shadowboxing	20 min	3x3 min rope, 3x3 min shadow
Wed	REST	—	Active recovery: light walk or stretch
Thu	Bag rounds	20 min	5x3 min rounds, RPE 6-7
Fri	Jump rope intervals	20 min	30 sec fast / 30 sec slow x 20
Sat	Long slow run	40 min	RPE 5-6 — build aerobic base
Sun	REST	—	Full recovery

Week 1 Tips:

Focus on breathing rhythm. Exhale on every strike. Never hold your breath during bag rounds — this is the most common beginner mistake.

WEEK 2 — ADD INTENSITY

Goal: Introduce higher intensity intervals. Start feeling the burn but keep technique clean.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	Interval run	30 min	1 min fast / 2 min jog x 10
Tue	Jump rope + bag rounds	30 min	4x3 min rope, 4x3 min bag RPE 7
Wed	REST	—	Stretch or light yoga
Thu	Shadowboxing circuits	25 min	5x3 min: jab-cross-teep combos non-stop
Fri	Hill sprints or stair runs	20 min	10x30 sec sprint, walk back down
Sat	Long run + bag finisher	50 min	35 min run + 3x3 min bag RPE 8
Sun	REST	—	Full recovery

Week 2 Tips:

Your legs will be sore — that's normal. The teep (push kick) is one of the most cardio-intensive techniques. Practice it non-stop for a full round to build specific Muay Thai conditioning.

WEEK 3 — FIGHT SIMULATION

Goal: Train like you're preparing for a fight. 5-round sessions, mix of all tools.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	5-round bag session	35 min	5x3 min full pace, 1 min rest — RPE 8
Tue	Roadwork intervals	35 min	2 min fast / 1 min jog x 10
Wed	Active recovery	20 min	Light shadowboxing + stretching
Thu	Circuit: rope/shadow/bag/burpees	30 min	4 rounds of all 4, 30 sec each, no rest
Fri	Sprint finishers	25 min	10x100m sprints — full recovery between
Sat	Full fight simulation	45 min	5x5 min rounds: shadow+bag+rope rotation
Sun	REST	—	Full recovery — mandatory

Week 3 Tips:

The circuit on Thursday is brutal — that's the point. Muay Thai fights don't pause between techniques. Training without rest between stations teaches your body to keep moving when it wants to stop.

WEEK 4 — PEAK & TEST

Goal: Hit peak conditioning then taper. By end of week you should last 5 full rounds without gassing.

Day	Session	Duration	Focus
Mon	Peak bag session	40 min	6x3 min bag, RPE 8-9
Tue	Interval run — peak	35 min	1 min max / 1 min jog x 15
Wed	REST	—	Full rest — body preparing for peak
Thu	Light technical session	25 min	4x3 min shadowboxing — focus on form
Fri	5-round test	35 min	5x3 min bag at RPE 9 — track how you feel
Sat	Easy jog	30 min	RPE 5 — flush the legs
Sun	REST	—	Celebrate — you made it

Week 4 Tips:

Friday is your test. If you can do 5x3 min bag rounds at high intensity and still feel in control at the end, your base cardio is fight-ready. Compare how round 5 felt in week 1 vs week 4.

KEY DRILLS EXPLAINED

Teep Cardio Drill

Stand in front of the bag. Alternate left and right teeps (push kicks) for a full 3-minute round without stopping. Sounds simple — it will destroy your cardio in the best way. This replicates the leg and hip flexor demand of a real Muay Thai round.

Switch Kick Intervals

30 seconds of switch kicks at maximum speed, 30 seconds rest. Repeat 10 times. The switch kick requires a full-body rotation — it taxes your core, hips, and conditioning simultaneously.

Shadowboxing with Burpee Finish

2 minutes of shadowboxing (jab-cross-hook-teep combos), then 10 burpees immediately. No rest between. Repeat 5 times. This simulates the oxygen debt of a real fight.

Jump Rope Pyramid

1 min easy > 2 min medium > 3 min fast > 2 min medium > 1 min easy. No rest between levels. Jump rope is the single best Muay Thai cardio tool — it builds footwork, timing, and aerobic capacity simultaneously.

Clinch Conditioning

With a partner: 2 minutes of clinch work (grip fighting, knee strikes, off-balancing). No breaks. If solo: grab a heavy bag and practice pulling it toward you and driving knees for 2 minutes straight.

NUTRITION FOR MUAY THAI CARDIO

You don't need a complicated diet. Follow these basics and your training will improve:

Pre-training (1-2 hrs before)

Small meal with carbs + protein. Rice and chicken, oats with eggs, banana with peanut butter. Avoid training on a full stomach.

Post-training (within 30 min)

Protein + carbs to start recovery. Protein shake + banana, or rice and eggs. This window matters most for cardio recovery.

Hydration

Drink water consistently all day — not just during training. Dehydration kills cardio performance faster than anything. Aim for 3-4 litres on training days.

What to avoid before training

Heavy meals, alcohol, excessive caffeine. If you feel sick during bag rounds, you ate too close to training.

WHAT'S NEXT

You've built the cardio base. Now make sure your gear matches your training level. The wrong gloves, shin guards, or Thai pads can slow your progress — or worse, cause injury.

Take our free gear quiz at muaythai-gear-quiz.vercel.app and get personalized recommendations based on your training style, budget, and experience level.

muaythai-gear-quiz.vercel.app